



Data Governance, in 6 steps.

A practical no-fluff guide to start a governance program in your org. From data folks to data folks.

1. Scope

2. Owners

3. Definitions

4. Access

5. Quality

6. Reviews

WELCOME

Stop trying to boil the ocean.

Most data governance programs fail for the same reason: they try to govern everything at once, write a 100-page policy nobody reads, and lose momentum after three months.

This kit takes the opposite approach. Six small steps you can finish in under a week. Each step is one page, with a checklist, a real example, and a 'watch out for' warning from people who've made the mistake.

Print it. Mark it up. Give it to your team. Then come back and tell me which step was hardest at @thedatasteward.

How to use this kit

Work through one step per workday. Don't skip ahead. By Friday you'll have the bones of a real governance program — for ONE data domain.

Pick ONE data domain.

01

The biggest reason governance programs fail is trying to govern everything at once. Pick the data domain that hurts most when it's wrong, and start there.

DO THIS

- ☐ List your top 5 most-used data domains (customer, finance, product, etc.)
- ☐ Pick the ONE that causes the most pain when it's wrong
- ☐ Write down WHY it matters. One sentence.

EXAMPLE

Pick "customer data" if your sales team and marketing team can't agree on how many customers you have. That disagreement is your governance opportunity.

WATCH OUT FOR

The 'boil the ocean' trap. If your scope is more than ONE domain, narrow it. You can expand later. You cannot un-fail a too-broad first attempt.

Name a real human.

"The data team owns it" means nobody owns it. Every data domain needs ONE accountable owner (decides) and ONE steward (watches over it).

DO THIS

- ☐ Pick the Data Owner — usually a business leader who cares about the domain
- ☐ Pick the Data Steward — usually closer to the data, day-to-day caretaker
- ☐ Tell them. In writing. Confirm they accept the role.

EXAMPLE

Customer data: Owner = VP of Customer Success. Steward = Senior Analyst on the Revenue Ops team. Both names are written in your team wiki.

WATCH OUT FOR

Naming people without their consent. Have the conversation first. An unwilling owner is worse than no owner.

Define your top 5.

In every domain, there are 5 fields or metrics that get debated, misinterpreted, or break things when wrong. Define those. Ignore the rest for now.

DO THIS

- ☐ List 5 critical fields/metrics in your chosen domain
- ☐ Write a plain-language definition for each. No SQL.
- ☐ Document the source of truth (which system 'wins' if they disagree)
- ☐ Note who can change the definition

EXAMPLE

"Active customer = anyone who logged in within the last 30 days." Source of truth: the auth system. Definition can be changed by the Data Owner only.

WATCH OUT FOR

Definitions that are too technical. "Active customer = anyone with a session in last 30 days" beats "AC = U.last_login >= now() - 30d".

Set your access rules.

04

Decide who can see, edit, or change what. Default to minimum access. Audit periodically. This is the boring step that prevents fines and leaks.

DO THIS

- ☐ Define 3-5 access tiers (e.g. Read-only, Editor, Admin)
- ☐ Map your roles to those tiers
- ☐ Set a quarterly review reminder on your calendar
- ☐ Document every exception when you grant temporary access

EXAMPLE

Read-only: All employees. Editor: Analytics team. Admin: Data Owner + 1 backup. Vendor X gets temporary read-only access for project Y, expires 2026-08-01.

WATCH OUT FOR

"Just give them access for now" with no expiration. Three years later, that vendor still has prod access. Document everything, even the temporary stuff.

Pick 3 quality checks.

05

You can't fix what you don't measure. But you also can't act on 50 metrics. Start with 3 simple, automated checks. Add more only after you actually use them.

DO THIS

- ☐ Pick 3 simple checks: row counts, null %, and data freshness work for almost everyone
- ☐ Set thresholds that trigger alerts (not just dashboards)
- ☐ Decide who gets the alert. A human, not a Slack channel.
- ☐ Run them on a schedule (daily for freshness, weekly for the rest)

EXAMPLE

Daily: customer_table row count. Alert if today's count is < 95% of yesterday's. Alert goes to the Data Steward via SMS, not a channel where it'll be ignored.

WATCH OUT FOR

50 metrics nobody looks at. Three you actually act on are infinitely better. Resist the urge to add more until the first three are working.

Schedule the review.

Without a recurring review, governance dies in 3 months. Set a 30-min monthly meeting. Standing agenda. Hard cap. Don't skip it.

DO THIS

- ☐ Calendar invite. Recurring monthly. 30 minutes max.
- ☐ Standing agenda: quality issues, access changes, definition updates
- ☐ Attendees: Data Owner, Data Steward, ONE stakeholder
- ☐ Five-minute readout to the broader team after each meeting

EXAMPLE

Last Wednesday of every month, 2:00-2:30 PM. Owner, Steward, and rotating analyst attend. Notes go in the team wiki. Cancellation requires 48h notice.

WATCH OUT FOR

Letting it grow into a 2-hour meeting with 12 attendees. Hard cap at 30 minutes and 3 people. If you need more, you're doing too much per meeting.

Print this. Tape it to your monitor.

- ☐ **01 Pick your scope**
ONE data domain. The one that hurts most when wrong.
- ☐ **02 Name your owners**
ONE Data Owner + ONE Data Steward. Real humans.
- ☐ **03 Define your top 5**
5 fields/metrics. Plain-language definitions. Source of truth.
- ☐ **04 Set access rules**
3-5 access tiers. Map roles. Quarterly review.
- ☐ **05 Choose 3 quality checks**
Counts, nulls, freshness. Alerts to a human.
- ☐ **06 Schedule monthly review**
30 min. Standing agenda. Hard cap.

WHAT NOW?

Don't let this PDF die in your downloads.

Pick step 1. Block 30 minutes on your calendar this week. Do that step. Tomorrow, do step 2. By next Friday you'll have the foundation of a real data governance program — without ever opening a PowerPoint.

Tag me with your wins

Show me your checklist, your meeting notes, even your war stories. I'll repost the best ones.

@thedatasteward